

Civil Disobedience

prc-civil-disobedience

Christian Ethics · Civil Authority · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Christians submit to civil authority as God's servant, but must obey God rather than man when laws command sin or forbid commanded obedience.

In plain language

The question asks whether Christians must obey civil rulers as God's servants AND must obey God instead when a human law commands sin or forbids something God commands. The lexical evidence is unusually clean. In Romans 13:1 the present passive imperative 'let him be subject' (hypotassestho), an ongoing command in the form of 'be acted upon', commands every soul 'every soul' (pasa psyche) to keep being subject to the higher authorities, and Paul grounds this in a clause that says there is no authority except from God and that existing authorities have been 'ordained' (tetagmenai) by God. The ruler is then named 'God's servant' (theou diakonos) twice in one verse. Subjection is therefore the standing rule, and ranging oneself against the office is set against God's own arrangement. In Acts 5:29 the apostles answer with a fixed maxim, 'it is binding to obey God rather than men' (peitharchein dei theo mallon e anthropois). The impersonal 'it is binding' (dei) signals divine necessity, and the comparative 'rather than' (mallon e) ranks the two obligations only at the point where they collide. The cleanest single proof that the canon means what the proposition says is this: the verb 'to obey one in authority' (peitharcho), Strong's G3980, occurs only four times in the New Testament, and Paul uses it in Titus 3:1 to command obedience to 'rulers and authorities' (archais exousiais), while the apostles use the same verb in Acts 5:29 toward God. The canon uses one word in both directions and ranks them only by 'rather than' (mallon e) at the conflict point. 1 Peter 2:13-17 ties the same knot, 'be subject to every human institution for the Lord's sake' (hypotagete pase anthropine ktisei dia ton kyrion), then 'fear God, honor the king' (phobeisthe ton theon, timate ton basilea), using different verbs for each. The Old Testament defiance narratives act it out: the Hebrew midwives feared God and the text rewards them, the three refuse the image and accept the furnace, Daniel keeps praying and accepts the lions' den, and Hebrews 11:23 praises Moses' parents for not fearing the king's 'edict' (diatagma). In every case the believer submits to the lawful penalty while refusing the sinful command. The lexical pattern supports both halves of the proposition, default subjection plus a God-priority limit, with high confidence across narrative, law, and epistle, and the same root family carries the duty both ways.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0426	אלהים	elah	god	
H0430	אלהים	elohim	God	
H3372	ירא	yare	to fear	
H6680	פקח	tsavah	to command	
H6739	מצלח	tsela	to pray	

G0191	ἀκούειν	akouō	to hear	
G0436	ἀντίστημι	anthistemi	to oppose	14
G0444	ἄνθρωπος	anthropos	a human	567
G0498	ἀντιτάσσω	antitasso	to resist	5
G0746	ἀρχαῖς	archē	beginning	
G0758	ἄρχων	archōn	ruler	
G0935	βασιλέα	basileus	king	
G1163	δεῖ	dei	be necessary	107
G1249	διάκονος	diakonos	servant	33
G1296	διαταγή	diatage	ordinance	2
G1297	διάταγμα	diatagma	edict	
G1558	ἐκδικος	ekdikos	avenging	
G1849	ἐξουσία	exousia	authority	103
G2316	θεός	theos	God	1,360
G2962	κύριον	kurios	lord	
G3123	μᾶλλον	mallon	more	81
G3709	ὀργή	orgē	wrath	
G3956	πάσῃ	pas	all	
G3980	πειθαρχέω	peitharcho	to obey	4
G5091	τιμήσατε	timaō	to honor	
G5293	ὑποτάσσω	hypotasso	to subject	42
G5399	φοβεῖσθε	phobeō	to fear	

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Romans 13:1 commands 'let him be subject' (hypotassestho), a present passive imperative (an ongoing command in the form of 'be acted upon'), of 'every soul' (pasa psyche), and grounds the duty in 'there is no authority except from God' (ouk estin exousia ei me hypo theou). Romans 13:2 then warns that 'the one ranging himself against the authority' (ho antitassomenos te exousia) 'has set himself against the ordinance of God' (anthesteken te tou theou diatage). Acts 5:29 supplies the limiting clause with the same root family: 'it is binding to obey God rather than men' (peitharchein dei theo mallon e anthropois). Decisively, the very verb 'to obey one in authority' (peitharcho), Strong's G3980, is also the verb Paul uses in Titus 3:1 to command obedience to rulers, 'to be subject to rulers and authorities, to be obedient' (archais exousiais hypotassesthai peitharchein), so the canon uses ONE word in both directions and ranks them only by the comparative 'rather than' (mallon e) at the point of conflict. The Old Testament defiance narratives, Exodus 1, Daniel 3, Daniel 6, enact the same pattern: refuse the sinful command, accept the lawful penalty.

Scripture

Rom.13.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5293 ὑποτασσέσθω, G1849 ἐξουσία, G2316 θεοῦ

Reasoning. The verb 'let him be subject' (hypotassestho) is third person singular present passive imperative (an ongoing command in the form of 'be acted upon') of 'be subject' (hypotasso), so the command is for every soul to keep being subject to the higher 'authorities' (exousiai). The subject 'every soul' (pasa psyche) leaves no class exempt. The grounding clause 'there is no authority except from God' (ouk estin exousia ei me hypo theou), and the perfect passive participle 'have been ordained' (tetagmenai, a completed action whose result still stands, in the form of 'have been acted upon'), anchors every existing authority in God's own appointment. That grounding is the seed of the limiting clause: the duty is derivative, not absolute, because the office is God's, not its own.

Rom.13.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0498 ἀντιτασσόμενος, G1296 διαταγή, G0436 ἀνθέστηκεν

Reasoning. 'the one ranging himself against' (ho antitassomenos), a present middle participle (an ongoing action the subject does to or for himself) of 'range oneself against' (antitassomai), names the one who ranges himself against the authority. The verb 'has set himself against' (anthesteken) is perfect (a completed action whose result still stands) of 'stand against' (anthistemi), has come to stand against and now stands against, the 'ordinance' (diatage) of God. The noun 'ordinance' (diatage), only twice in the New Testament, links the human institution back to a divine arrangement, so ordinary resistance is opposition to God's order, not merely to a magistrate. The verse condemns rejection of the office, which is consistent with refusing a specific sinful command without rejecting the office itself.

Rom.13.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1249 διάκονός, G2316 θεοῦ, G1558 ἐκδικος

Reasoning. The ruler is named 'God's servant' (theou diakonos) twice within one verse, and 'an avenger for wrath' (ekdikos eis orgen) on the wrongdoer. The lexical chain is repeated and emphatic: the authority is functional, instrumental, and accountable to the God whose servant it is. That servant framing is the hinge that allows the higher claim of God to override a lower claim of his servant when they diverge, without rejecting the institution itself.

Acts.5.29 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G3980 πειθαρχεῖν, G1163 δεῖ, G2316 θεῷ, G0444 ἀνθρώποις, G3123 μᾶλλον

Reasoning. 'it is binding to obey God rather than men' (peitharchein dei theo mallon e anthropois). 'to obey one in authority' (peitharcheo), Strong's G3980, is the verb for obedience to one in authority and occurs only four times in the New Testament. The impersonal 'it is binding' (dei) marks divine necessity. The comparative 'rather than' (mallon e) names a ranking, not a rejection. The construction does not deny that men have any claim, it ranks God's claim above the human claim precisely at the point of conflict. This is a comparative limit on the human claim, not its abolition.

Acts.4.19 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G2316 θεοῦ, G0191 ἀκούειν, G3123 μᾶλλον

Reasoning. 'whether it is right before God to listen to you rather than to God' (ei dikaion estin enopion tou theou hymon akouein mallon e tou theou) frames the same 'rather than' (mallon e) choice as a question of righteousness before God one chapter before Acts 5:29 states it as a maxim. The two passages set up a fixed apostolic pattern, not a one-off exception.

Tit.3.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5293 ὑποτάσσεσθαι, G3980 πειθαρχεῖν, G1849 ἐξουσίαις, G0746 ἀρχαῖς

Reasoning. Paul stacks the two key verbs of this whole question side by side: 'to be subject to rulers and authorities, to be obedient' (archais exousiais hypotassesthai peitharchein). The verb 'to obey one in authority' (peitharchein) here, Strong's G3980, is the SAME verb the apostles use in Acts 5:29 toward God. The canon therefore uses one word in both directions, and so the question is not whether to obey men, the answer is yes, but how to rank that obedience when a particular human command conflicts with God's. The vocabulary itself is the bridge between Romans 13 and Acts 5:29.

1Pet.2.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5293 ὑποτάγητε, G2962 κύριον, G3956 πάση

Reasoning. 'be subject to every human institution for the Lord's sake' (Hypotagete pase anthropine ktisei dia ton kyrion). The aorist passive imperative (a completed past action in the form of 'be acted upon', used as a command) of 'be subject' (hypotasso) is paired with 'for the Lord's sake' (dia ton kyrion), naming the Lord as the reason for the subjection, which mirrors Romans 13's 'from God' (hypo theou) grounding. The duty is owed for the Lord's sake, and that framing again caps the duty at the Lord himself when the two claims would diverge.

1Pet.2.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5091 τιμήσατε, G5399 φοβεῖσθε, G2316 θεὸν, G0935 βασιλέα

Reasoning. 'fear God, honor the king' (ton theon phobeisthe, ton basilea timate). The verbs are deliberately different, 'fear' (phobeo) for God and 'honor' (timao) for the king, and they are not interchangeable in the verse. The king receives 'honor' (time), the same word Paul uses in Romans 13:7. God alone receives 'fear' (phobos) in the loaded sense. The lexical asymmetry inside one sentence is the Old Testament and apostolic pattern in miniature: real obedience to civil authority, but reserved fear, the deepest loyalty, for God.

Exod.1.17 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H3372 יָרָא, H0430 יָרָא

Reasoning. The Hebrew midwives 'the midwives feared God' (wattirena hammeyalledot et haelohim), and so did not act as the king of Egypt spoke to them, 'and they did not do as he had spoken' (welo asu kaasher dibber). The verb 'fear' (yare) with 'God' (elohim) as object names the loyalty that overrules the king's word. The narrator then records that God blessed them and built them houses. The text approves the act lexically by attaching divine reward, not merely by reporting the refusal.

Dan.3.18 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H0426 אֱלֹהֵינוּ, H6680 פָּלַח

Reasoning. The three answer that even if their God whom they serve does not deliver them, they will not serve the king's gods or worship the gold image. The verb 'to serve' religiously (palach) is the very verb the decree commanded for the image, so they refuse the religious act of submission while accepting the furnace as a civil penalty. The text combines refusal of the sinful command with acceptance of the lawful punishment, which is the exact contour of the proposition.

Dan.6.10 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H6739 מְצַלָּח, H0426 אֱלֹהֵינוּ

Reasoning. Daniel continues praying toward Jerusalem three times a day 'as he had been doing before' (kal qabel di hawah abed min qadmat denah). The decree forbade petition to any but the king. Daniel preserves the prior commanded act of worship and accepts the lions' den as the civil penalty. The text emphasizes the continuation of the previous practice, marking the issue as a forbidden act of commanded obedience, exactly the second half of the proposition.

Heb.11.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5399 φοβηθέντες, G1297 διάταγμα

Reasoning. Moses' parents hid him three months 'not fearing the king's edict' (me phobethentes to diatagma tou basileos). The cognate of 'ordinance' (diatage) from Romans 13:2 appears here as 'edict' (diatagma), and the action of disobeying it is recorded 'by faith' (en pistei) in the roll call. The same noun family that grounds the duty of submission also names the kind of edict that may rightly be refused when it commands the killing of an innocent child.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.5.29	Acts.4.19	tsk	1
Rom.13.1	1Sam.2.8	tsk	1
Rom.13.1	Deut.17.12	tsk	1
Rom.13.4	Rom.12.19	tsk	1
Rom.13.7	Exod.20.12	tsk	1
Rom.13.5	1Sam.24.5	tsk	1
Acts.5.29	Tit.3.1	openbible	1
Rom.13.1	1Pet.2.13	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Rom.13.1 · addressed

The unqualified 'every soul, let him be subject' (pasa psyche hypotassestho) could be read as absolute, unconditional obedience, which would contradict Acts 5:29 and the Old Testament defiance narratives. The grounding clause resolves it lexically: subjection is owed because the authority is 'ordained by God' (hypo theou tetagmene), so the duty cannot extend to commands that set the creature against the God who ordained the office. The norm is general, not absolute, by the very logic the clause itself supplies.

Rom.13.2 · addressed

'the one ranging himself against' (antitassomenos) opposing the 'ordinance' (diatage) of God appears to condemn all non-compliance. But the object 'range oneself against the authority' (antitassomai te exousia) takes is the standing authority and the divine ordinance of authority, not a particular sinful command of a magistrate. Refusing a specific command to sin is not opposing God's ordinance, it is honoring the God whose servant the authority is, as Acts 5:29, Titus 3:1 with 'to obey one in authority' (peitharchein) used both ways, and the Daniel narratives demonstrate.

1Pet.2.13 · addressed

'be subject to every human institution for the Lord's sake' (Hypotagete pase anthropine ktisei dia ton kyrion) appears to ground subjection without limit. But the prepositional phrase 'for the Lord's sake' (dia ton kyrion) caps the duty at the Lord himself. A subjection done 'for the Lord's sake' (dia ton kyrion) cannot extend to an act that the 'Lord' (kyrios) forbids, as 1 Peter 2:17's contrast between 'fear' (phobeo) for God and 'honor' (timao) for the king inside the same paragraph confirms.

1Sam.24.5 · addressed

David's stricken conscience for cutting Saul's robe shows restraint toward the Lord's anointed even when wronged, and could be pressed toward absolute passivity under unjust rulers. The text limits private vengeance and armed rebellion against the office, not the refusal to personally commit a sin commanded by the office, so it coheres with the proposition's narrow exception rather than overturning it.

Concordance traversed

G5293, G3980, G1849, G0498, G0436, G1296, G1163, G3123, G1249, G2316, G0444, G0758, G1558, G3709

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units in the bundle bear on the verdict. The Romans 13:1 apparatus marks word-order and the 'from God' (hypo theou) reading, but every attested reading still grounds the authorities in God. Acts 5:29 'it is binding to obey God rather' (peitharchein dei theo mallon) is textually stable across NA27, NA28, SBL, WH, Treg, TR, Byz (standard editions and manuscript families of the Greek New Testament), so the verdict holds across plausible readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked

absolute-subjection reading of Rom 13: partial · Read in isolation, 'let him be subject' (hypotassestho) and 'the one ranging himself against' (antitassomenos) look unconditional, and on that lens the apostles in Acts 5:29 should have complied with the sanhedrin. The lens has real lexical purchase on the unqualified universal 'every soul' (pasa psyche), and on the warning that resisters incur 'judgment' (krima). But it cannot account for 'it is binding to obey God rather than men' (dei theo mallon e anthropois) in Acts 5:29, for Hebrews 11:23's praise of Moses' parents for not fearing the king's 'edict' (diatagma), or for Daniel 3 and Daniel 6 commending refusal. 'comparing Scripture with Scripture' (analogia scripturae) corrects it to a general norm with a God-priority limit.

harmonized norm-with-exception reading: affirms · Treating Romans 13 and 1 Peter 2:13-17 as the default duty and Acts 4:19, 5:29, and the Old Testament defiance narratives as the limiting clause where the two commands conflict integrates every cited text. The lexical bridge is Titus 3:1, which uses 'to obey one in authority' (peitharchein), Strong's G3980, of human rulers and Acts 5:29 which uses the same verb of God: the canon uses one word in both directions, and only the comparative 'rather than' (mallon e) ranks them at the conflict point.

anarchist or political-quietist reading: denies · A reader could press Acts 5:29 and the defiance narratives to deny any positive duty to civil authority, treating Romans 13 as concession to weak conscience. The lens is real but does not survive the lexical data: Romans 13:1 grounds the authorities in God, Romans 13:4 calls the magistrate 'God's servant' (theou diakonos) twice, 1 Peter 2:13-14 commands subjection 'for the Lord's sake' (dia ton kyrion), and Titus 3:1 stacks 'to be subject' (hypotassesthai) with 'to obey one in authority' (peitharchein) toward 'rulers and authorities' (archais exousiais). The duty is positive, not concessive.

The verdict rests on reading the Romans and 1 Peter commands together with the Acts maxim, not pitting them against each other. The lexical hinge is repeatedly grounding the authority in God, 'from God' (hypo theou), 'ordinance of God' (diatage theou), 'God's servant' (theou diakonos), 'for the Lord's sake' (dia ton kyrion), so a higher claim of God can override a lower claim of his servant without contradicting the institution itself. The use of the SAME verb 'to obey one in authority' (peitharcheo), Strong's G3980, toward both God and rulers in the canon is the decisive cross-link.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The proposition is balanced and tradition-neutral. It states the default duty of subjection AND the limiting condition, laws commanding sin or forbidding commanded obedience, in descriptive terms rather than smuggling a verdict into the stem. The verdict is derived on the original stem from the lexical evidence.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.13.1

morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.13.2
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.5.29
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Tit.3.1
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Pet.2.13
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5293
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3980
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0498
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1296
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3123
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H3372
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.5.29
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rom.13.1

License audit

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